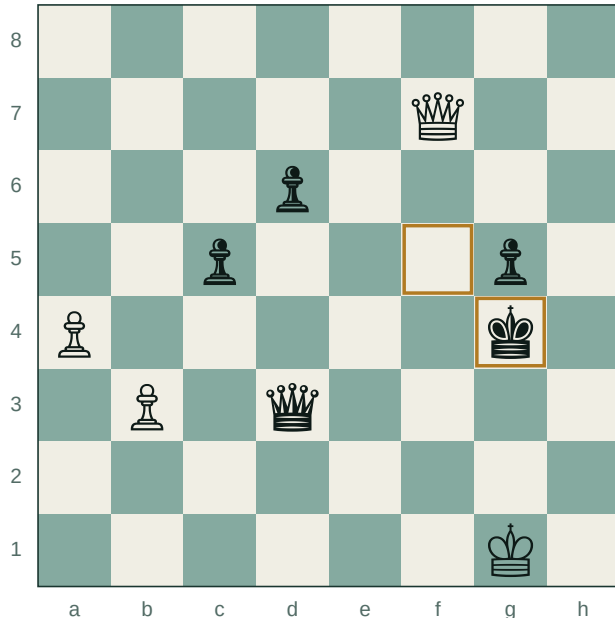


Queen-ending tactics: White, move 49

Queen-ending tactics

White to move



Previous move: 48...Kg4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

49. Qc4+ Qxc4 50. bxc4 Kf5 51. a5

49.Qc4+ Check restricts Black to 8 legal replies here. From c4 it attacks king on g4 and queen on d3. Recorded reply: **49...Qxc4**.

50.bxc4 The pawn captures the queen on c4. Recorded reply: **50...Kf5**.

51.a5 The pawn moves from a4 to a5.

At the end, nominal material is White 2 / Black 3 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from -1 to -1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A favorable-looking queen exchange can lead to a drawn pawn ending. Evaluate the new ending before simplifying.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Queens combine long-range checks with promotion support. King shelter and the order of checks often matter more than a small material lead.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect perpetual-check possibilities, queen trades, and checks that gain a tempo for a passed pawn.

The defending king is on g4. Geometrically undefended: queen on d3. Check for tactical protection.